



IIT ROORKEE



NPTEL ONLINE
CERTIFICATION COURSE

Public Speaking

Lecture 13: Glossophobia

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Glossophobia: Is it for real?

- ❑ Glossophobia (the Greek γλῶσσα *glossa*, meaning tongue, and φόβος *phobos*, fear or dread) refers to the fear of public speaking. It is an anxiety disorder, a phobia characterized by constant and extreme fear of a situation or an object.
- ❑ Individuals suffering from glossophobia experience fear and anxiety while speaking in front of a group of people.
- ❑ As a result, they avoid speaking in public. Fear of rejection dominates their every public interaction.
- ❑ Over time, this may result negative impacts on their mental health and efficiency.



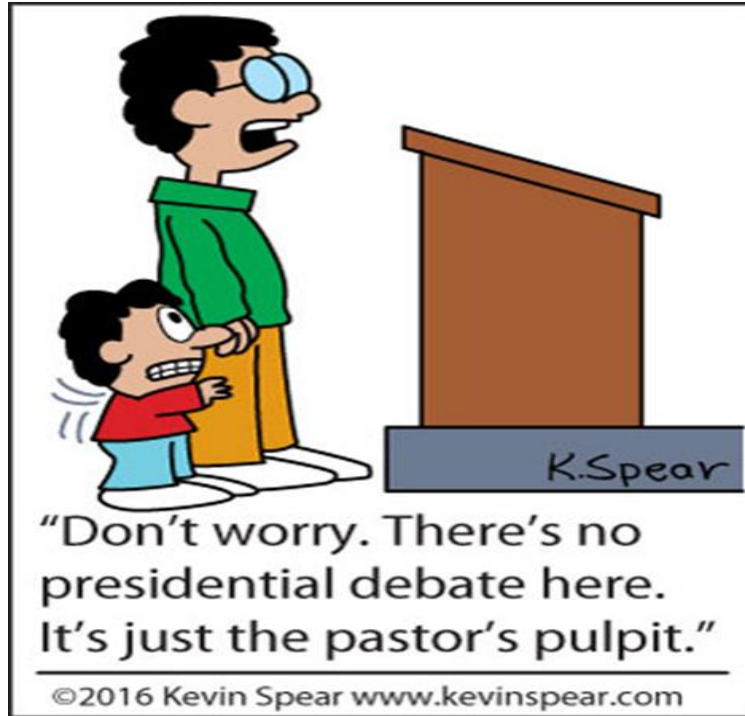
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Symptoms of Glossophobia



"I believe that I shall never be old enough to speak without embarrassment when I have nothing to say."
-Lincoln

Glossophobia: Its Range and Reach



- Glossophobia is a common form of anxiety.
- More than 75% of population have this form of anxiety.
- This anxiety can range from slight nervousness to paralysing fear and panic attacks.

"He who fears death will never act as becomes a living man". – Seneca

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Diagnosing Glossophobia

- ❑ People suffering from glossophobia may show the following indications while preparing for public speaking:
 - Faltering with Words
 - Indecisive about Content
 - Unfamiliarity with the Receiver
 - Unfamiliarity with the Situation
 - Poor Listening
 - Emotional instability



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According to Mulac and Sherman, there are four elements in speech fright:



Anxiety Behaviours (Mulac and Sherman)

Voice

- Tense Voice
- Too fast
- Too slow
- Monotonous: lack of emphasis

Verbal Fluency

- Nonfluencies: stammering
- Vocalized pauses
- Hunts for words: speech blocks

Mouth and Throat

- Swallows
- Clears Throat
- Breathes Heavily

Facial Expression

- Lack of Eye contact
- Tense face muscles
- Deadpan facial expression

Arms and Hands

- Rigid or tense
- Fidgeting
- Motionless

Gross Bodily Movements

- Sways
- Paces
- Shuffles feet

Flight-or-Fight Reaction

People who suffer from glossophobia experience flight-or-fight reaction because of the adrenaline produced in human body. It is a primitive response that still exists in our body. Once conquered, one can overcome the fear of public speaking.



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Famous Public Orators with Glossophobia

❑ Some of the famous people with Glossophobia are:

- Renée Zellweger
- Nicole Kidman
- Abraham Lincoln
- Mahatma Gandhi
- Sigmund Freud
- Thomas Jefferson



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A Psychologist's Observation

“Our natural survival devices take over to prepare us for an emergency. Our muscles tense for better agility, our heartbeat and breaths quicken to provide large supplies of fuel, our glands secrete fluids to sharpen our senses and give us emergency energy.”

-William James

Anxiety (also called solicitude) is a psychological and physiological state characterized by cognitive, somatic, emotional, and behavioral components. These components combine to create an unpleasant feeling that is typically associated with uneasiness, fear or worry.

-Seligman, M.E.P., Walker, E.F. & Rosenhan, D.L. (2001). Abnormal psychology, (4th ed.) New York: W.W. Norton & Company, Inc. ...

How to overcome Glossophobia?

Preparation and Persistence are immensely locomotive in overcoming glossophobia.



There are several steps that one can follow in order to overcome glossophobia:

❑ **Know your topic:**

A better understanding of the content of speech can do wonders. The more an individual familiarises with the topic, the chances are lesser to be derailed from the topic altogether.

❑ **Get organized:** One should always strive to stay ahead of time and carefully plan the information to be shared, the props and the audio-visual aids required. An outline of the complete interaction should be pictured and jotted down.

☐ **Practice alone can make you perfect**

- ✓ Practice is the key for overcoming glossophobia. If possible, one can always seek for honest feedback from people whom one can trust initially. Later, one can present in front of lesser-known crowd. Recording oneself while presenting can be extremely helpful for improvement while watching the video.

☐ **Challenge specific worries**

- ✓ Making a list of all the specific worries can really help an individual. One can then directly challenge them by identifying probable outcomes and working accordingly.

Visualize success

- ✓ One has to imagine that the presentation will go well. Law of attraction is for real and positive thoughts can decrease some negativity about social performance and relieve some anxiety.

Do some deep breathing exercises

- ✓ This can be very claming in maximum cases. Taking two or more deep, slow breaths repeatedly can ease the strain. One should definitely do this before reaching the podium or entering a conference room for presentation.

☐ **Focus on material, not on the audience**

- ✓ Audiences tend to pay attention to novel information more than how it is being presented. They may or may not notice the nervousness. It is true one has to speak to the audience but content is the kingdom one needs to stay loyal to as well.

☐ **Do not fear moments of silence**

- ✓ One might lose track of what one is saying or begin to feel nervous or mind might run blank, the silence that follows seems eternal but it's not. It is probably for only a few seconds. Even if it is longer, it is likely that audience won't mind a pause to consider what is being talked of. Remember to take slow and deep breaths when that happens.

Recognize success

- ✓ After the presentation, speech, or any act of public speaking, one needs to appreciate oneself. The delivery may or may not have been perfect, but an individual is likely to be more critical of oneself than the audience. Reach out and find whether your worries occurred in actuality. Everyone makes mistakes and there is always room for improvisation.

Get support

- ✓ Join groups that offer help. One can seek professional help if the fear is not being overcome by these practices. Never shy away from help, it only makes an individual stronger.

**“Decide that you want it more than you are afraid
of it.” -Bill Cosby**

Thank You

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